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The Proof of Faithfulness

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The Proof of Faithfulness

Today's Reading: John 15:18-25

Hearing God's Voice for Today:

"If the world hates you, know that it has hated me before it hated you...I chose you out of the world, therefore the world hates you...A servant is not greater than his master. If they persecuted me, they will also persecute you...Whoever hates me hates my Father also."

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If you are a faithful follower of Jesus, the world will hate you. Don't be surprised when that happens. It first hated him.

Why does the world hate him? There are several reasons.

First, Jesus' life exposes human pride. It shows how we trust in our own insights and ways. It shows self-exaltation and worship of self. It proves we want the world to revolve around us so that we get all the fame and glory. By contrast, his followers want only God to receive the glory.

Second, we want to control our own life. We want to oversee all the shots and yield control to no one. But the Lord calls us to yield control of our life and trust him. He tells us that if we try to save our life, we will lose it. But if we give up our life for his sake and the sake of the gospel, we will gain it.

Third, we want to earn our own salvation. We think we are good enough to enter heaven, but we aren't. Jesus says that all fall far short of the glory of God. We need a Savior who will save us by grace, not our works. Only he can make this possible. We are offended when we hear that salvation is by his grace alone.

Jesus chose you out of the world to follow him. That means you are to reject the world's values. You now belong to him and possess his kingdom values. They are completely different than the world's values. The way you live for Jesus should remind people of their rebellion against him. As you live for him, the world will hate you as it hated him.

The servant is not greater than the master, nor is the pupil greater than the teacher, nor is the disciple greater than the mentor. If it happened to Jesus, it will happen to you. If people hate the word of truth, the world will hate it when you speak and live it.

When people hate you, don't retaliate or seek revenge. Leave those individuals to heaven. The Lord will rightly deal with them when the time is right.

You may feel lonely at times. Don't despair. Jesus will be with you wherever you may go. Even when you go through deep waters, he will be there with you. Don't ever be shaken. Call upon the Lord and he will whisper to you, "I am right here."

Yes, Jesus chose you from the world. Nevertheless, he calls you back into the world. You are to be in the world, but not of it.

You are Jesus' light in a dark world. Shine brightly for his glory!

You are Jesus' salt in a decaying world. Be very salty!

You are Jesus' ambassador to the world. Represent him well!

And don't be surprised when the hatred comes.

It shows you're being effective for your Lord.

[from "*Hearing the Voice of God*" by Pastor David Chadwick, *Moments of Hope Church*, Charlotte, NC]